Chapter 8

The Six Ingredients of Success

"With hard work comes knowledge, respect, wealth, and more"

These words are very popular. The most coveted possessions in life – health, wealth, knowledge, meaningful relationships, and respect – are all rooted in the soil of diligent effort. The capacity to achieve anything through sheer hard work is a remarkable gift, special to human kind.

Yet, it is also in our experience that, many times, our efforts don't yield the desired fruits. Students who fail after studying hard, dedicated and hardworking employees overlooked for promotion, and people whose ailments remain despite treatment. The list goes on. Sincere love that is misunderstood, favours that are left unappreciated, and service activities that do not give satisfaction, are all familiar to us.

What could be the reason behind such failures? Isn't success achievable through effort alone? Or are there other factors that control our successes? Such thoughts are likely to arise

in anyone's mind at such moments. Scholars posit that there are other factors supporting the success of efforts. There is a subhashita that reveals six necessary qualifications in addition to effort, for all round achievement -

प्रसन्नमूर्त्तिः समुदारचेताः वम्शाभिमानी शुभवाग्विलासः |
अनीतिभीतिर्गुरुसाधुनम्रः साम्राज्यलक्ष्मीं लभते मनुष्यः ||

prasannamūrtti: samudāracetā: vamśābhimānī śubhavāgvilāsa:
anītibhītirgurusādhunamra: sāmrājyalakṣmīṃ labhate manuṣya:

A person who has a pleasant demeanour, a noble mind, pride in their lineage, eloquent speech, fear of wrong doing, and humility towards the Masters and the virtuous, attains the wealth and prosperity of an empire.

This subhashita reveals what kind of a personality it takes to make that great achievement of full and well rounded success. Only a person who is pleasant, magnanimous, proud of their lineage, speaks auspicious words, fears wrongdoing, and is humble towards teachers and virtuous individuals can attain such success. Let us examine these six qualities, which accompany effort, and form the foundation of success.

1. Prasannamūrttih

This means, 'a person with a pleasant disposition'. The great malayalam poet K C Keshavapillai highlights the importance of a pleasant demeanour thus, "The Purushothama (supreme human being) is one who has grace in his face, compassion in his eyes, and sweetness in his words." Highlighting the greatness of such pleasantness in attitude, Swami Vivekananda says, "Despair, whatever form it may take, is not a religion. By being content and having a pleasant face, you are approaching God. No prayer has this power"[1]. To remove the obstacles in our path to victory,

[1] 'Thus Spake Vivekananda', Sri Ramakrishna Math Chennai, 1987.

we chant in the beginning of all our rituals, this invocation-

शुक्लाम्बरधरं विष्णुं शशिवर्णं चतुर्भुजम् ।
प्रसन्नवदनं ध्यायेत् सर्वविघ्नोपशान्तये ||

śuklāmbaradharaṃ viṣṇuṃ śaśivarṇaṃ caturbhujam
prasannavadanaṃ dhyāyet sarvavighnopaśāntaye

I meditate upon (Lord Ganesa), the one who wears a white garment, who is all-pervasive, who has a (bright) complexion like the moon, who has four hands, who has a cheerful face, for the removal of all obstacles.

Here, pay attention to the word 'Prasannavadanaṃ' (pleasing face). Doesn't the statement that the 'Prasannamoorthi' (the one with a pleasing face) removes obstacles indicate that our own 'Prasannata' (pleasing nature) leads us to victory?

2. Samudāracetāh

Samudāracetāh means 'one who has a generous mind'. Generosity is always superior to selfishness. But to be generous one needs a lot of patience. We can see a lot of tales portraying this virtue in our Itihasas and Puranas, and in the annals of our history.

Let us visit a popular short story. One day, a poet from the court of King Bhoja[2] was walking through the streets of the capital at noon. The ground was scorching hot due to the sun. At the same time, an old beggar was walking along the street. He had no footwear and was walking with great difficulty. Seeing the beggar in such a pitiable state, the poet's heart melted. The poet gave his own sandals to the beggar. Although the sandals were old, they were still usable. The beggar was relieved, but the poet was now in discomfort. He had never walked without sandals

[2] King Bhoja (1010-1055 CE) was a renowned scholar-king of the Paramara dynasty. He is celebrated for his contributions to literature, architecture, and education. Bhoja authored or commissioned at least 84 works on diverse subjects. He founded the city of Bhopal and constructed the Bhojeshwar Temple.

before. Now, the ground was scorching, and his feet burned. The poet hurried along. Just then, the king's mahout came by with the royal elephant. Seeing the royal poet in distress, the mahout quickly helped him onto the elephant. After a short distance, they encountered King Bhoja himself, travelling in his chariot along the same path. Seeing the poet on the elephant, King Bhoja asked in amazement, "How did you get on the royal elephant?" The royal poet replied with a verse,

उपानहं मया दत्तं जीर्णं कर्णविवर्जितम् ।
तत्पुण्येन गजारूढो न दत्तं वैहि तद्गतम् ॥

upānahaṃ mayā dattaṃ jīrṇaṃ karṇavivarjitam
tatpuṇyena gajārūḍho na dattaṃ vaihi tadgatam

I gave away my old, strapless sandals.
That merit lifted me onto the elephant.
What is not given is as good as lost, is it not?

The profound meaning of this statement greatly impressed the noble-hearted King Bhoja. He gifted the elephant to the poet! We do not need to be wealthy to show generosity. It is enough to share a portion of what we have with those in need. This act of sharing is praised as a sacrifice, a principle that sages repeatedly emphasised as a way of life that should never be forsaken. To understand the true essence of generosity, one only need to look at the life of the generous Amma. 'Give! Give! Keep on giving!' - that is the motto of Amma, who has made selflessness her life's vow. This generosity is one of the fundamental principles of success.

3. Vamśābhimānī

It means, 'one who takes pride in one's heritage and lineage'. As Indians, we all have a magnificent heritage in our claim. The very meaning of the name 'Bharat' is 'one that revels in light', 'to find happiness in the light of knowledge.' We are destined to walk in the light of the most sacred knowledge.

This is the land once ruled by the Rajarshis. The Rishis of Bharat are ones who bore witness to that which forms the foundation of this whole world. We should be proud to be the descendants of these great Rishis, and the selfless rulers, and of the people who were ruled by them. We are the descendants of King Shibi, who donated parts of his own body to save a dove. The great Sage Dadhichi is our ancestor, who sacrificed his bones to defeat the asuras.

न कामयेऽहं गतिमीश्वरात् पराम् अष्टर्द्धियुक्तामपुनर्भवं वा ।
आर्तिं प्रपद्येऽखिलदेहभाजाम् अन्तःस्थितो येन भवन्त्यदुःखाः ॥

na kāmaye'haṃ gatimīśvarāt parā-
maṣṭarddhiyuktāmapunarbhavaṃ vā
ārtiṃ prapadye'khiladehabhājā-
manta:sthito yena bhavantyadu:khā:

I do not desire the supreme position, endowed with the eight perfections, nor liberation from rebirth. I seek only to alleviate the sufferings of all living beings who have taken on physical bodies, by residing within them.

Srimad Bhagavatam 9.12.21

We follow in the footsteps of King Rantideva, who prayed, "I do not desire the eight perfections or even liberation from rebirth from the Lord. I only wish to reside within all living beings, taking on their suffering, and freeing them from misery." If we embrace even a fraction of such noble ideals, we too can make our lives truly successful. For this, we must take pride in being the descendants of these illustrious figures who embody these ideals.

4. Śubhavāgvilāsah

It means, 'a person who uses auspicious words'. The influence of words in the world is well known. There is a popular subhashita,

लक्ष्मीर्वसति जिह्वाग्रे जिह्वाग्रे मित्रबान्धवाः।
जिह्वाग्रे बन्धनं प्राप्तं जिह्वाग्रे मरणं ध्रुवम्।।

lakṣmīrvasati jihvāgre jihvāgre mitrabāndhavāḥ
jihvāgre bandhanaṃ prāptaṃ jihvāgre maraṇaṃ dhruvam

On the tip of the tongue resides Lakshmi. On the tip of the tongue relatives and friends are sustained. On the tip of the tongue is bondage. Death too is on the tip of the tongue.

Subhashitaratnabhandagara 155.87

There goes a saying, "Good words are essential for all achievements". As Amma says, "Appropriate words are like a golden key that can open any heart. The same words, if used wrongly, can lock any heart. By paying enough attention to the words we use, we can bring spring not only to our own lives but also to the lives of others."

The power of words to lift us out of difficult situations is indescribable. Recall Bhagavad Gita, and how the words of Sri Krishna uplifted Arjuna from his despondency. Remember Ramayana, where Jambavan's words imparted great strength to Hanuman to accomplish a monumental task. Think of Hanuman's graceful speech that brought Sita Devi from the depths of despair to the golden shores of hope while she was imprisoned by Ravana. Speaking auspicious words is an unwritten rule we must invariably follow to make our lives blessed.

5. Anītibhītih

It means, 'a person who fears wrongdoing'. This is a popular sloka written with Sri Rama and Ravana in mind,

यान्ति न्यायप्रवृत्तस्य तिर्यञ्चोऽपि सहायताम् ।
अपन्थानं तु गच्छन्तं सोदरोऽपि विमुञ्चति ।।

yānti nyāyapravṛttasya tiryañco'pi sahāyatām
apanthānaṃ tu gacchantaṃ sodaro'pi vimuñcati

Even animals assist those who act according to justice.
But when one strays from the righteous path,
even their own brother will abandon them.

Anargharaghava, Act 1, Verse 5.

"Those who strive for their goals through righteous means are even supported by birds and animals. However, even a brother will abandon someone who strays from the path of righteousness". This reminds us about Sri Rama and Ravana. Sri Rama had to make great efforts to rescue Sita. Monkeys, bears, and even squirrels were ready to support Rama, who was dedicated to righteousness. Conversely, what about the story of Ravana? Ravana, who followed the path of injustice, was abandoned even by his own brother, Vibhishana. Only the path of justice brings lasting achievements. Those who gain power, wealth, and knowledge through unjust means will eventually lose everything.

Duryodhana ruled the kingdom for thirteen years after deceitfully winning it through a rigged game of dice. Ultimately, he was left with only the destruction of his dynasty and a legacy of infamy. Karna deceitfully obtained his martial skills by deceiving his teacher, but it did not serve him well in the end. This principle illustrated in the Itihasas and Puranas can also be observed in modern history.

Even today, we see these scenarios playing out around us. Only those who fear following the path of injustice can achieve true success. The path of righteousness is the royal road that leads to the pinnacle of victory.

6. Gurusādhunamrah

This means, 'a person who is humble before the Guru and virtuous people'. Humility is the quality that makes one deserving of wealth, power, and knowledge -

विनयात् याति पात्रताम्

Vinayād yāti pātratām

Through humility, one becomes deserving.

Hitopadesha 6

Only when one becomes deserving, only when one earns merit, can one's desires be fulfilled. A person who lacks respect for teachers and virtuous people is considered arrogant.

Nature never tolerates such individuals. Amma emphasises. "A violent storm can uproot trees, but it can't do anything to grass." According to divine law, all achievements flow towards those who are humble. Remember the proverb, "Water always flows to low land; it is only there God gives support." This is why it is said, "Pride comes before a fall, but humility comes before honour."

Humility and devotion towards the Guru are essential to reach and maintain great heights. There are countless stories of those who, due to a lack of reverence for the Guru (Gurutvam), have failed to achieve success or lost the successes they had gained. Humility towards the Guru and the virtuous is indispensable for our success.

Remember Poonthanam's words in Jnanappana, "When you see virtuous people, bow down without any shame."[3] To attain the grace essential for ultimate success, humble devotion to teachers and virtuous individuals paves the way.

Conclusion

When combined with effort, these six foundational elements of success ensure that our efforts bear fruit. They bring us the

[3] സജ്ജനങ്ങളെക്കാണുന്ന നേരത്തു ലജ്ജ കൂടാതെ വീണു നമിക്കണം.
sajjanaṅṅaḷĕkkāṇunna nerattu lajja kūṭātĕ vīṇu namikkaṇaṃ.

Goddess of Victory, the Vijaya Samrajya Lakshmi. They instil in us self-confidence and guide us forward on the path to success.

We often measure success in terms of effort and hard work alone, but true, lasting, and well-rounded success requires more. To support the roof of success, there are six essential pillars, which correspond to the features of a personality (as given in the sloka):

1. Prasannamūrttih - One of Cheerful Disposition
2. Samudāracetāh - One with Generous and Noble Mind
3. Vamśābhimānī - One with Pride in his Heritage and Lineage
4. Śubhavāgvilāsah - A Person with Talent for Gracious and Auspicious Speech
5. Anītibhītih - One Who Fears Wrongdoing
6. Gurusādhunamrah - One Who is Humble before Teachers and Virtuous People.

These qualities attract grace and good fortune, while shielding us from downfalls. They make us worthy to receive the blessings of success. They offer a guiding framework to ensure our successes have genuine substance and are worthy of being called "victories".

Let us strive to inculcate these ennobling qualities alongside our diligent efforts. By doing so, we open the doors to realising our highest potential and supreme accomplishment.